CRISIS COMMUNICATION & STAKEHOLDER MANAGEMENT

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1. Incident overview and communication objectives

Exactly 08:15 on Monday, the organization's critical file share became unavailable, preventing several teams from accessing shared files. The security team is preserving evidence and investigating. Ransomware is suspected but the cause, scope and entry point have not been confirmed. Payroll processing is scheduled for Friday and may be delayed if access is not restored. An unverified screenshot has appeared in a staff group chat and is spreading outside the organization.

The communication response will provide timely, audience-specific information while protecting the investigation and organizational trust. It will use one authorized source of truth, distinguish verified facts from unknowns, give employees practical instructions, assess business continuity and regulatory obligations, and establish reliable fallback channels if normal collaboration systems are unavailable.

1.1 Confirmed facts, unknowns and working assumptions

Category	Position at the start of the response
Confirmed Fact	Exactly 08:15 on Monday, the critical file became unavailable, several teams could not access shared file. Payroll is schedule for Friday and maybe delayed if access is not restored. Security is preserving evidence and investigating, and unverified screenshot is circulating on staff group chat.
Unknowns requiring verification	Whether ransomware is confirmed, entry point, attacker identity, numbers and types of system affected. Whether information was accessed, exposed, recovery time. Whether payroll will be possible on Friday. Whether legal or regulatory notification duty has been triggered.
Working assumptions for planning only	HR, IT, Legal, Risk, Finance/payroll and Communications can nominate authorized contact. A team should establish an approved communication channel outside the affected environment. These assumptions must be checked and not presented as fact.

2. One-Page Incident Communication Plan

Time(proposed)	**Communication/Audience**	**Purpose and key content**	**Owner and Approval**
08:30	Incident command alignment- Incident commander, IT/Security, finance/payroll, HR, Risk and Legal communication	Confirm the fact: list unknowns, identify business critical services, appoint spokespersons, agree secure out-of-band channels	Communication Lead coordinators: Incident commander approves; IT/security and validates relevant contents.

09:00	Employees holding statement: all employees	Acknowledge file-share disruption, give safe work instruction, address the unverified screenshot without validating, give next update time.	HR and Communication distribute, Incident Commander approves.
10:00	Executive and critical partner briefing	Explain operational impact, payroll deficiency, knowns/unknowns, containment and continuity work.	Incident commander brief executives, finance/payroll and IT provides validated inputs, Legal reviews external wordings.
12:30	Situation updates-employees and relevant stakeholders.	Situation updates-employees and relevant stakeholders. identity unresolved issues and state the next checkpoint	Communications prepares; relevant functional owners verify, Incident Commander authorizes.

Timing note: These are proposed planning checkpoints within the assignment's 08:30–12:30 first communication window. If a material development occurs, the Incident Commander may authorize an earlier update. If there is no material change, issue a short checkpoint confirming that investigation continues rather than remaining silent.

3. Stakeholder map and communication matrix

Stakeholder Group	Main Information Need	Message Owner	Requested Action	Escalation Trigger
Direct workforce	Which systems are affected; safe working instructions; where to get help; what is and is not known about payroll?	HR with Communications	Do not forward the screenshot or speculate; report suspicious messages through the approved route; use only authorized workarounds.	Initial holding message by 09:00; update at 12:30 and when instructions materially change. Escalate safety, suspected compromise or inability to perform critical duties.
Executive leadership and Board	Business impact, operational exposure, payroll risk, response status, decisions and resource needs.	Incident Commander: Communications supports.	Approve urgent resources and business-continuity options; assign decision owners; maintain oversight.	Initial briefing by 10:00; at least every two hours during the initial response or sooner on a material change. Escalate

				financial, legal or reputational exposure.
Key customers and B2B clients	Whether their services or information are affected; service continuity; trusted contact route.	Customer Relations / Account Management with Legal and Communications clearance.	Use designated contact points; report customer-facing disruption; do not circulate unapproved technical claims	Contact when impact is verified, or a contractual communication threshold is reached; provide a scheduled update. Escalate confirmed client impact or missed service commitments.
Regulatory bodies and legal counsel	Accurate incident chronology, verified impact, evidence status, potential data or service implications and applicable obligations.	Legal/Compliance, supported by IT/Security and Risk.	Assess applicable statutory, regulatory and contractual notification duties; preserve privileged advice and an auditable decision record.	Legal assessment begins immediately; notify within applicable required timelines if threshold is met. Escalate evidence of reportable impact or a deadline approaching.
Banking and payroll clearing partners	Payroll processing dependencies, file/transaction boundaries, cut-off times, alternate processing arrangements and authentication requirements.	Finance/Payroll and Treasury/Operations, with Legal approval.	Confirm cut-off times and secure contingency procedures; validate any alternate instructions independently.	Contact promptly where a dependency or cut-off may be affected; reconfirm at agreed milestones. Escalate risk to Friday payroll or payment integrity.
Incident response and technology teams	Scope, indicators, containment instructions, evidence handling, restoration dependencies and approved technical status.	IT/Security lead.	Preserve logs and evidence; follow incident command; provide verified status and avoid unapproved public statements.	Operational updates at agreed incident-bridge intervals; immediate escalation for spread, privileged-account compromise, evidence loss or material scope expansion.

4. Employee Holding Statement

Subject: Temporary Disruption to Shared files — staff Guidance

We are aware that the organization’s critical file share became unavailable at approximately 08:15 this morning, affecting access for several teams. Our IT and security teams are investigating the disruption and preserving relevant evidence. The cause and full scope have not yet been confirmed.

You all may have seen a screenshot circulating in staff group chats. It has not been verified by the organization. Please do not forward it, treat it as confirmed information or speculate about its contents. If you receive a suspicious message or believe you have relevant evidence, report it through the approved incident contact route and do not delete or alter it.

For now, do not attempt unauthorized workarounds, connect unapproved storage devices or use personal accounts to transfer company information. Continue essential duties only where approved systems and instructions permit. Managers should identify work that is blocked and report operational dependencies through the designated channel.

Payroll is scheduled for Friday; however, we cannot yet confirm whether the disruption will affect processing. We are assessing contingency options and will provide the next staff update by 12:30 today. Please rely on authorized organizational updates pending when issues are resolved.

5. Customer / Business Partner Update

Subject: Operational Update

We are currently managing an interruption affecting access to an internal file-sharing service. Our technology and security teams are investigating the cause, preserving relevant evidence and assessing any operational impact. At this stage, the scope of the disruption and any effect on specific customer or partner services have not been fully established.

We are reviewing continuity arrangements and will contact affected parties directly if verified information indicates that an agreed service, transaction or processing milestone may be impacted. Please continue to use your established, verified contact channels and independently confirm any unusual request to change payment, account or processing instructions. We will not ask you to act on unverified screenshots or informal messages.

We will provide a further update by 12:30 today, or sooner if confirmed information requires an earlier communication.

6. Executive Briefing

To: Executive Leadership / Board Representative

From: Incident Commander, supported by Communications Lead

Time: 10:00 Monday (proposed first leadership briefing)

Subject: Initial operational briefing — critical file-share outage during payroll week

6.1 Situation and Confirmed Facts

- At 08:15 Monday, the critical file share became unavailable and several teams cannot access shared files.
- The security team is preserving evidence and investigating.
- Ransomware is suspected but has not been confirmed; the screenshot circulating among staff is unverified.
- Payroll is scheduled for Friday and may be delayed if access is not restored.

6.2 Key Unknowns

- Cause, entry point, attacker identity and technical scope.
- Whether systems beyond the file share are affected and whether data was accessed or exfiltrated.
- Expected restoration time and whether clean recovery is possible.
- Whether payroll files, approval workflows or partner connectivity are affected.
- Whether legal, regulatory, contractual or customer notification thresholds are met.

6.3 Principal Risks

- Operational interruption and reduced staff productivity.

- Payroll delay, payment errors or missed partner cut-off times.
- Further compromise or evidence loss if staff use unauthorized workarounds.
- Confidentiality, legal, regulatory and contractual exposure if data impact is established.
- Reputational damage and misinformation caused by unverified screenshots or inconsistent messages.

6.4 Decisions Requested

1. Confirm the Incident Commander's authority and the approved spokespersons for internal and external communications.
2. Approve necessary incident-response resources and a secure out-of-band communication method independent of the affected file-sharing environment.
3. Direct Finance/Payroll to map Friday's processing dependencies, cut-off times and controlled contingency options with banking/payroll partners.
4. Direct Legal/Compliance to assess applicable notification duties and preserve the rationale for any notification or non-notification decision.
5. Require business owners to identify critical activities that are blocked and approve only controlled, secure workarounds.

6.5 Next Checkpoint

The next coordinated situation update is proposed for 12:30 Monday. The Incident Commander should authorize an earlier briefing if the investigation confirms broader system impact, data exposure, compromise of privileged access, a material payroll dependency or a notification deadline requiring immediate action.

7. Channel-Resilience Plan

The response must not depend on the affected file share, corporate email or a collaboration platform that may be unavailable or compromised. The organization should use only pre-approved, authenticated channels that have been tested and are independent of the affected environment.

Purpose	Primary Channel	Feedback Channel	Owner	Receipt/Identity Confirmation
Incident command	Pre-approved secure incident-response platform on an independently managed environment, if verified safe.	Pre-established telephone bridge using a known dial-in and participant list.	Incident Commander / IT Security.	Roll call; each function lead verbally confirms receipt and repeats assigned actions.
All employees	Approved mass-notification/SMS service independent of corporate identity and email systems.	Manager telephone tree using current, verified contact details.	HR/ Communications.	Delivery report plus manager acknowledgement to a designated incident contact.
Executive leadership	Approved secure executive alert channel independent of affected systems.	Direct calls to pre-verified executive numbers.	Incident Commander/ Executive Office.	Recipient repeats key decision or instruction; decision logged by the scribe.

Customers and partners	Established, verified account-management contact route or approved customer notification service.	Direct telephone contact using previously verified numbers.	Customer Relations/ Account Management.	Record recipient, time, channel and acknowledgement; independently verify sensitive instructions.
Regulators / legal counsel	Approved secure legal or regulatory submission channel, as advised by Legal.	Verified telephone contact followed by the required formal written channel.	Legal/ Compliance.	Retain submission receipt, reference number or documented acknowledgement

Channel safety controls: Verify the channel and recipient before sending; do not share credentials or sensitive incident details in public group chats; do not trust new contact details supplied in an unexpected message; use a second, known route to authenticate high-risk instructions; maintain a time-stamped communication log; record failed delivery and retry via the approved fallback.

8. Escalation Rationale

The incident should be escalated immediately to the Incident Commander because the unavailability of a critical file share is already affecting several teams and has occurred during a time-sensitive payroll cycle. The suspected ransomware element, the circulation of an unverified screenshot and the possibility of wider operational or information-security impact make coordinated oversight necessary. Early escalation does not mean presenting ransomware as confirmed; it means bringing the right decision-makers together while facts are established.

The Incident Commander should escalate to executive leadership without waiting for complete technical certainty where there is evidence of spread beyond the initial file share, compromise of privileged accounts, loss or exposure of sensitive information, interruption to a critical service, a credible threat to payroll cut-off times, or a legal, regulatory or contractual notification deadline that may be triggered. Legal and Compliance should assess the applicable obligations promptly and document the basis for the decision.

I would not claim that ransomware has been confirmed, identify an attacker, state how the incident began, quantify affected systems, declare that data has or has not been exposed, or provide a recovery time unless the relevant evidence has been validated by the responsible technical leads. I would also not promise that Friday payroll will proceed as scheduled. Such assurances could mislead employees and partners, undermine trust and create avoidable legal or operational consequences.

The response should nevertheless communicate early. Employees need safe instructions, leaders need decision-ready information and partners may need to protect processing cut-offs. The balance is to communicate confirmed facts, clearly label unknowns, explain the actions underway and commit to a definite next checkpoint. This approach is transparent without being speculative

9. Critical Reflection

The most difficult communication dilemma was how to reduce employee anxiety about Friday's payroll without promising an outcome that the organization could not yet verify. Employees depend on timely salaries, so silence or vague language could increase fear and encourage rumors. However, assuring staff that payroll would definitely proceed could be misleading because the file-share outage, its scope and its effect on payroll dependencies were still being investigated.

I addressed this tension by acknowledging the Friday payroll date, explaining that its potential impact was being assessed and committing to a specific update time. I also gave employees practical instructions and asked them not to circulate the unverified screenshot. This allowed the organization to communicate promptly while protecting the investigation and avoiding unsupported claims. The approach recognizes that trust is built not by pretending to know everything, but by being clear about what is known, what remains uncertain, who is taking action and when stakeholders will hear from the organization again.